

UC BERKELEY

Police: Pokemon card stolen in Facebook Marketplace setup



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Berkeley police say Flock license plate data and cellphone records linked suspect Xavier Alvarez to the crime.



A Pokemon Pikachu character figure (stock photo). [Michael Rivera](#) / [Unsplash](#)

A young man charged with stealing a \$5,000 Pokemon card from a [UC Berkeley](#) student is set to appear in court today to determine if his case will go to trial.

Zavier Alvarez is scheduled to appear Tuesday morning for a preliminary hearing, where key evidence is presented to a judge who decides if the case can proceed.

On March 31, the victim arranged to sell the Pokemon "Pikachu" card to a buyer via Facebook Marketplace, [Berkeley police](#) wrote in court papers.

The next night, they met in a commercial parking lot at 10th and Gilman streets at 8 p.m.

But when the victim took out the card, the buyer — a clean-shaven Black man in his early 20s with a thin build — grabbed the card and ran north toward Gilman, police wrote.

The victim initially tried to chase him but stopped when he saw the thief get into a gray sedan with several other people inside, authorities said.

When the student tried to research the buyer on Facebook, he found he'd been blocked, police wrote.

The next day, the stolen card — still in its "distinctive case with sparkle trim" — was up for sale again on Facebook Marketplace, according to charging papers.

So the victim's friend set up a meeting with the seller, Xavier Alvarez, police wrote.

During the meeting, the victim, who was waiting nearby, recognized Alvarez from the prior night's getaway car, according to court papers.

Meanwhile, the friend took back the Pokemon "Pikachu" card and refused to pay for it "because the card was stolen."

During their investigation, police also linked Alvarez to the Berkeley getaway car via [Flock license plate data](#) as well as a 2025 traffic stop in Oakland, police wrote.

Daly City police also tied him to the Berkeley scene via cellphone records, as they were investigating him in a different case, BPD wrote. His phone number also linked him to a robbery case in Mountain View, they continued.

In charging papers, police wrote that Alvarez, who is 21, had been arrested in other counties on suspicion of robbery, vehicle theft and firearm possession.

Berkeley police arrested Alvarez in early May at his home in Pittsburg, police wrote.

After his arrest, Alvarez admitted to setting up the victim to steal the card, colluding with others and "knowingly attempting to sell the stolen card back," according to charging papers.

The Alameda County district attorney's office charged him with grand theft and receiving stolen property, both felonies.

Alvarez was released on his own recognizance May 8 and ordered to appear in person at future hearings.

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